

2026-07-19 — הַמָּפִיל, Hareini Mochel, and the Maharam's Prison Seder

Independent review · read fresh, no exposure to the writing process · 26 July 2026

1. Overall Read

This is an ambitious, wide-scope write-up: a full sugya on הַמָּפִיל (Chayei Adam vs. Mishnah Berurah, with a Rav Asher Weiss twist), the הריני מוחל material anchored in the Zohar, and then a structural walk-through of the Maharam's prison seder as the spine of the nightly practice. The write-up is generally coherent and earns most of its length — the CA/MB machloikes is genuinely well-developed, and the Maharam frame gives the back half a strong organizing image. But the piece is too long for its own good in places, and the ending doesn't so much *land* as *taper*: sections XIII–XV drill into components of the Maharam's seder that were already listed in XI, and the "Practical Guidance" close (XVI) reads as bullet-point administration rather than an arc-completing moment. The double-summary at top (lead paragraph) and bottom (paragraph 302) both run through the entire arc, which underlines that the piece is *architected* rather than *told*.

2. What Works

- **The Chayei Adam / Mishnah Berurah pair (V and VI)** is the strongest sequence in the piece. The Chayei Adam's move — starting with the daytime-nap ruling and using it as a foil to force the nighttime distinction — is set up cleanly, and the Mishnah Berurah's singular-לשון counter is stated crisply in one paragraph. A reader who came in cold could reproduce both positions from these two sections.

- **The Chayei Adam biographical callout (after V)** is exactly the kind of Artscroll-expansion that earns its space: the "merchant-baal-halacha with שולחן ערוך in his wagon" detail actually deepens the halachic argument, because the CA's whole shittah on nighttime הַמַּפִּיל is calibrated to the practical bedside experience of a lay Yid. Biography and lomdus reinforce each other.
- **The transition from the Zohar's story to the Pele Yoetz warning (IX)** is well engineered. First the aspirational picture (double נס, surpassing Yosef), then the sincerity guardrail (Tehillim 101), then the sharp counter-move (offender's duty is independent). The section works because those three beats sit against one another rather than compounding the same point.
- **The שישים גיבורים / sixty-letters remez (XIV)** is the moment of the piece with the most staying power. The pasuk-count, the "מפחד בלילות" phrase, and the image of the ברכה placing sixty warriors around your own bed — all of it lands in a tight two-paragraph move.

3. Where It's Weak or Could Be Sharper

- **The lead paragraph is punishing.** It's essentially one paragraph-long sentence stitched with semicolons and dashes that rehearses the entire arc before the reader has committed to reading. And then paragraph 302 (inside the ~~מחנה~~ מקומות recapitulates the same arc a second time. Either the front summary or the back one should go, and whichever survives should be broken into 3-4 sentences.
- **Sections XI → XII → XIII feel out of order.** Section XI introduces the Maharam's prison seder as the structural spine of the nightly practice. Then XII interrupts with a self-contained halachic framework on early-~~מחנה~~ ~~הכוכבים~~ Maariv/הכוכבים that references "last week's Rabbeinu Tam / Rashi discussion" — this is a leftover from prior week's setup, and inserting it between the Maharam frame and its components (XIII-XV) breaks the flow. XII would sit

better earlier, near the gemara/RC girsa section (II).

The Maharam narrative in XI is one of the more resonant hooks in the shiur, but the writeup underdevelops it. Two paragraphs of biography-plus-list, then it hands off. A shiur that named "the Maharam's prison seder" in its very title probably wants more room here — the seder's specifically ashkenazic character, why the **ח"מ** choices of which pesukim to include reflect a particular hashkafah, why exactly **לילה** bedtime carries the meaning it does *for a Yid in a cell*. As written, XI is functionally a bullet list with atmosphere.

The **ח"מ paragraph (XV) contradicts itself.** It roster-lists five angels (רפאל, גבריאל, מיכאל, נוראל) which is the standard five-letter reading with Uriel as the **ה**. Then the very next sentence says the **ח"מ** "additionally represents **ח"מ** — **הקב"ה** — **ח"מ** himself." Both claims cannot be simultaneously true for the same letter — either the acronym is five angels, or the **ח"מ** is **הקב"ה** and there are four angels. As written, a careful reader will trip on it.

The claim that the anonymous Yid's forgiveness "surpasses" Yosef HaTzadik's (IX) is stated but not really developed. The write-up gives it a "in a certain sense" hedge and then moves on. This is one of the more striking assertions in the shiur — it deserves a real half-paragraph unpacking *why* daily-universal-scope is meaningfully greater than one-time-dramatic-scope, or the claim should be softened. Presently it hits as a gesture rather than an argument.

The Reb Chaim callout (after III) is charming and probably functions well in the live shiur, but on the page the ratio of anecdote-length to halachic-payoff feels off. The point being made — that **לילות רעים** is not an archaic category — is a single sentence, and the anecdote runs six.

4.Factual / Citation Concerns

Footnote 5 (Rav Asher Weiss) already flags itself with a note-

academic that the specific published citation was not identified and is not

in Sefaria's corpus. That's honest, but it means the entire section VII is

presented in a citation-less form — worth having someone with Minchas

Osher on the shelf verify whether Rav Asher actually deploys the	תוספות
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argument in the form given, or whether this is a

reconstruction.

"Kaf HaChaim reversed his practice" on	אחריהם	חצות
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(callout after VIII) — this story is worth checking. The Kaf HaChaim

(R' Yaakov Chaim Sofer) is generally aligned with the	מקובלים and a
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public reversal of his personal practice against the	מקובלים would be
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notable. If it is real it typically comes with a specific siman/os citation;

none is given here.

"	הַטָּבַת חָלוֹם is spelled/transliterated " <i>hataavas chalom</i> " twice in the
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section III callout. The standard term is <i>hatavas chalom</i> (	הַטָּבַתThis
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may be a Yiddishized pronunciation preserved from the live shiur, but the

current spelling looks like a mistake.

Rabbeinu Chananel's girsa-emendation of	אמר(II, fn2) —
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attributing the *emendation* specifically to RC (as opposed to noting that

RC's text includes	אמר is a strong claim. Worth confirming that the
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language used in the writeup matches what RC actually says on the daf,

versus what is inferred from his girsa.

Bamidbar Rabbah 11:3 attributed to 'שמלאי'	ר(fn18) — the
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dominant	אשר	דרש derashos in Midrash Rabbah on Naso is
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R' Yehuda son of R' Shalom / R' Yishmael / others depending on the

specific	אקא R' Simlai is more famously associated with the taryag-
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mitzvos derashah. The specific "	אלו ששים אותיות שבברכת כהנים
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attribution should be verified against the actual midrash text.

Zohar Miketz (fn8) — the citation says "Exact page in the Zohar not

specified in the	שעור the passage is in the	פרשת מקץ section." The
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double-miracle-plus-nightly-forgiveness story is a well-known ma'aseh but

has some variants (some tellings feature different miracles or different

tanaim). Since the piece leans on it hard, it's worth pinning to a page

reference before publication.

5.Small Polish Suggestions

- The word "**structural**" appears roughly 20+ times ("structurally serious," "structural anomaly," "structural function," "structural spine," "structural priority," "structural teeth," "structurally

independent," "structurally excluded"). It has become a tic. A copy pass should demote about half of them to nothing or to a stronger word.

- Lead paragraph, the phrase "**and pushes through to the full nightly סדר**" — the verb *pushes through* is doing a lot of work; consider *carries through* or *reaches*.
- Section I, gan eden gate: "**the שומר — the שטן at the door**" — calling the gan eden gatekeeper "the שטן" is odd (שטן is a gehinom-associated figure, not a gan eden one). Consider dropping the "שטן" gloss and just calling him the שומר / gatekeeper.
- Section III callout: "**hataavas chalom**" (twice) — likely should be *hatavas* (הטבת חלום). Confirm and correct throughout.
- Section VIII, final paragraph: "**Some קהלות nonetheless preserve the older order per the Chayei Adam / earlier ראשונים**" — the "older order" hasn't actually been named in the paragraph. A one-clause insert ("— i.e., saying הַמִּפְּיל *first* and then קריאת שמע —") would rescue this sentence.
- Section IX subhead: "**The Zohar's Story — ר' אבא and the Double Miracle**" — the phrase "double miracle" then appears in the paragraph, again in the sincerity paragraph's aftermath, again in the callout referencing this section, again in fn8. Trim two.
- Section XI, list item 5: "**השכיבנו (without חתימת ברכה — see section XIII below)**" — the parenthetical forward-reference works, but item 4 (יושב בסתר) and item 6 (ברכת כהנים) also get later sections (XIV) with no forward reference. Either add both or drop the one you have.
- Section XIV: "**Sefarim explain the connection through a beautiful pasuk-remez**" — fn18 actually pins this to Bamidbar Rabbah 11:3 and R' Shimlai. Bring the mekor into the body ("the Midrash Rabbah in Naso — the דרשה of R' Shimlai on...") rather than deferring to the vague *sefarim*.

- Section XVI, closing bullet: **"do not lean on other people's nightly recitation to absolve your own duty to seek their forgiveness when you have wronged them"** — this restates section IX's Pele Yoetz warning almost verbatim, which is fine as a callback but flag it as one ("As the פלג יוני warned above: ...") so the reader recognizes it as recapitulation rather than a fresh point.

6.Bottom Line

Read it — the Chayei Adam / Mishnah Berurah / Rav Asher Weiss trio and the Zohar-plus-Pele-Yoetz section are worth the price of admission, but skim the lead paragraph and don't expect the back half's Maharam frame to fully deliver on the title's promise.

Produced by an independent-review pass — an agent given only the finished HTML and no prior exposure to the writing process. Intended as an outside second opinion for editorial refinement, not as a corrections list.